



PHP Sessions

Presented by
Nguyễn Đức Thái
Ho Chi Minh City University of Technology

What is PHP Session?

- A **session** is **a way** to store information (in variables) to be used across multiple pages.
- Unlike a cookie, the information is **not stored** *on the users computer*.

What is PHP Session?

- When you work with an application, you open it, do some changes, and then you close it.
- This is much like a Session.
- The computer knows who you are.
- It knows when you start the application and when you end.

What is PHP Session?

- But on the Internet there is one problem: the web server does not know who you are or what you do, because the HTTP address **doesn't maintain state**.
- Session variables solve this problem by **storing user information** to be used across multiple pages (e.g. username, favorite color, etc).

What is PHP Session?

- *By default*, session variables **last** *until the user closes the browser*.
- Session variables hold information about **one single user**, and are *available to all pages in one application*.

Start a Session

- A session is started with the `session_start()` function.
- Session variables are set with the PHP global variable: `$_SESSION`.

```
<?php
// Start the session
session_start();
?>
<!DOCTYPE html>
<html>
<body>

<?php
// Set session variables
$_SESSION["favcolor"] = "green";
$_SESSION["favanimal"] = "cat";
echo "Session variables are set.";
?>

</body>
</html>
```

- Note:
 - `session_start()` function must be the **very first thing** in your document.
 - Before any HTML tags.

Get PHP Session Variable Values

- Session variables are **not** passed individually to each new page, instead they are retrieved from the session we open at the beginning of each page (**session_start()**).
- All session variable values are stored in the global `$_SESSION` variable:

Get PHP Session Variable Values

```
<?php
session_start();
?>
<!DOCTYPE html>
<html>
<body>

<?php
// Echo session variables that were set on previous page
echo "Favorite color is " . $_SESSION["favcolor"] . "<br>";
echo "Favorite animal is " . $_SESSION["favanimal"] . ".";
?>

</body>
</html>
```


Get PHP Session Variable Values

- Another way to show all the session variable values for a user session is to run the following code:

```
<?php
session_start();
?>
<!DOCTYPE html>
<html>
<body>

<?php
print_r($_SESSION);
?>

</body>
</html>
```

How does it work?

- Most sessions set a **user-key** on the user's computer that looks something like this:

765487cf34ert8dede5a562e4f3a7e12

- Then, when a session is opened on another page, it scans the computer for a user-key.
- If there is a match, it accesses that session, if not, it starts a new session.

Modify a PHP Session Value

- To change a session variable, **just overwrite it**:

```
<?php
session_start();
?>
<!DOCTYPE html>
<html>
<body>

<?php
// to change a session variable, just overwrite it
$_SESSION["favcolor"] = "yellow";
print_r($_SESSION);
?>

</body>
</html>
```

Destroy a PHP Session

- To remove all global session variables and destroy the session, use `session_unset()` and `session_destroy()`:

```
<?php
session_start();
?>
<!DOCTYPE html>
<html>
<body>

<?php
// remove all session variables
session_unset();

// destroy the session
session_destroy();
?>

</body>
</html>
```

References

- W3 Schools – [w3schools.com](https://www.w3schools.com)